

Your Four Year College Admissions Roadmap

9th & 10th Grade

Build a Foundation, Explore Your Interests, and Lay the Groundwork

Successful college admissions is a four-year journey. Students who begin with intention in 9th grade arrive at the application stage with richer stories, stronger records, and far greater confidence. Use this grade-by-grade roadmap – developed by Fortuna’s former admissions officers – to stay ahead at every milestone.

9th Grade — Build a Foundation & Explore

- ✓ Take an appropriate level of challenging courses. You should feel stretched, but not burned out. Rigor matters, and so does sustainable performance
- ✓ Establish strong study habits and time management skills that will serve you throughout high school
- ✓ Explore extracurriculars broadly: sports, arts, community service, debate, academic clubs – try new things
- ✓ Start an Activity Log to record roles, hours, awards, and achievements as they happen
- ✓ Explore potential career interests and college majors – keep an open, curious mind
- ✓ Begin researching colleges casually: size, location, campus culture, academic programs
- ✓ Visit campuses if traveling nearby – early exposure helps you develop an understanding of what college experience will fit you best
- ✓ Pursue volunteer opportunities or passion projects that reflect who you are – not what might look good on paper

10th Grade — Deepen Involvement & Refine

- ✓ Continue to pursue a demanding but manageable level of rigor in your coursework
- ✓ Deepen commitment in 1-2 extracurriculars where you can show real growth, impact, and leadership
- ✓ Pursue a meaningful summer opportunity: academic program, internship, research, or creative project
- ✓ Take the PSAT in October (school-dependent) as an early benchmark
- ✓ Take a full-length practice SAT and ACT to identify your stronger test and baseline scores
- ✓ Develop a standardized testing plan and timeline for 11th grade
- ✓ Update your Activity Log with new achievements, leadership roles, and hours
- ✓ Continue college exploration – visit schools when the opportunity arises; talk with older friends about their choices
- ✓ Identify competitions, awards, or independent projects that could distinguish your profile
- ✓ Build genuine relationships with teachers who may one day write your recommendations

✦ **FORTUNA TIP** The Activity Log you start in 9th grade becomes the raw material for your Common App activities list in 12th grade. Track everything — roles, hours, achievements — from day one. You’ll be grateful you did.

11th Grade

Focus, Prepare, and Build Your Narrative

Junior year is the most consequential year of high school for college admissions. Your grades, test scores, leadership trajectory, and early essay thinking all crystallize this year. Approach each semester with clear intention and use the summer that follows to get a significant head start on applications.

Fall	Winter	Spring
✓ Maintain academic rigor: junior year grades are the last complete transcript admissions officers see ✓ Actively seek leadership roles in your key extracurriculars ✓ Take the PSAT in October; high scorers may qualify for National Merit recognition ✓ Consider sitting for the SAT or ACT in the fall to get a real score early ✓ Build a strong, candid relationship with your school counselor ✓ Begin constructing your college list – reach, target, and safety schools ✓ Research each school's academic culture, notable programs, and unique opportunities	✓ Conduct targeted research on application requirements, essay prompts, and institutional priorities for each school ✓ Plan and schedule campus visits for spring break or summer, if possible ✓ Research and apply to summer programs, internships, and research opportunities ✓ Deepen extracurricular impact and remember that the quality of involvement always outweighs quantity ✓ Begin reflecting on personal essay themes: what story can only you tell? ✓ Identify 2-3 teachers to approach for letters of recommendation and invest in those relationships	✓ Thoughtfully select senior year courses – continued rigor signals commitment ✓ Formally identify and approach recommenders; continue nurturing those relationships ✓ Start brainstorming and outlining your personal statement – aim for a draft before summer ends ✓ Research scholarship opportunities and note their deadlines alongside college apps ✓ Retake SAT or ACT if your score has room to grow ✓ Refine your college list based on research, campus visits, and honest self-assessment ✓ Draft an early version of your activities list and brag sheet ✓ Begin thinking about your Early Action or Early Decision strategy
SUMMER Before 12th Grade ✓ Draft your personal statement – aim for a near-final version before school starts ✓ Begin drafting supplemental essays for your top-choice schools using prior-year prompts ✓ Complete your Common App profile, activities list, and awards section ✓ Prepare your brag sheet for your recommenders ✓ Finalize your college list – confirm reach/target/safety balance ✓ Lock in your Early Action or Early Decision deadline strategy and identify priority application deadlines ✓ Rest, recharge, and pursue a meaningful summer experience to add to your story		

✦ **FORTUNA TIP** Junior year grades are the last complete transcript colleges review and carry the most weight in the admissions process, so academic focus during this year is critical. Use the summer wisely: students who arrive at 12th grade with a near-finished personal statement are usually much less stressed during the fall semester.

12th Grade

Finalize, Apply, and Make Your Decision

Senior year is the culmination of everything you've built. With a strong summer of preparation behind you, fall becomes about execution: polishing essays, submitting applications, and preparing for interviews. Winter brings the finish line and spring brings the decisions that open your next chapter.

Fall — Execute & Submit	Winter — Finish Strong	Spring — Decide & Celebrate
✓ Polish and finalize your personal statement – plan for multiple rounds of feedback and revision ✓ Build and maintain a master tracker of all requirements, deadlines, and submission statuses ✓ Complete and submit supplemental essays for all EA/ED schools ✓ Finalize SAT/ACT scores; send official score reports to schools as required ✓ Follow up with recommenders to confirm letters have been submitted ✓ Check in with your school counselor on transcript, school report, and mid-year updates ✓ Submit EA/ED applications – typically November 1 or November 15 deadlines ✓ Prepare thoroughly for alumni interviews if applicable	✓ Polish and submit all remaining Regular Decision essays – most deadlines January 1 or 15 ✓ Thank your recommenders ✓ Complete FAFSA as early as possible (opens October 1); submit CSS Profile where required ✓ Research and apply for external scholarships – track deadlines carefully ✓ Maintain strong grades – colleges review mid-year reports and can rescind offers ✓ Continue interview preparation for any outstanding alumni sessions ✓ Check all application materials were received; follow up on any gaps ✓ Receive EA/ED decisions – evaluate offers or plan next steps if deferred or waitlisted	✓ Receive Regular Decision admissions results – celebrate every acceptance! ✓ Attend admitted student events, open days, and virtual campus sessions ✓ Carefully evaluate financial aid packages, scholarship offers, and net cost at each school ✓ Request additional aid if needed – financial aid appeal letters can make a difference ✓ Weigh academic fit, campus culture, career opportunities, alumni networks, and location ✓ Consult trusted advisors – family, counselors, coaches – before making your final decision ✓ Commit to your school by May 1 (National Decision Day) – notify all other schools promptly ✓ Submit any required enrollment deposits, housing forms, or orientation registrations ✓ Notify your recommenders and counselor – share your good news!

✦ **FORTUNA TIP** Don't let senioritis undermine four years of hard work. Colleges review mid-year reports and can rescind offers for significant grade drops. Finish the year with the same determination that got you to this point, and this will also prepare you to hit the ground running at college!

Standardized Testing: A Four-Part Strategy

Testing strategy is most effective when planned early. Use the framework below to pace your preparation, identify your stronger test, and lock in a competitive score before the fall of senior year. That said, every student is different: some will be ready to test earlier, others may benefit from more preparation time before their first official sitting. Treat this as a guide, not a prescription, and adjust the timeline to suit your individual readiness and goals.

10th Grade	11th Grade — Fall	11th Grade — Spring	12th Grade — Fall
✓ Take a full-length practice SAT and ACT under timed conditions ✓ Identify which test better suits your strengths ✓ Develop a testing plan and prep timeline for 11th grade ✓ Take the PSAT if offered by your school	✓ Take the PSAT in October (potential National Merit qualifier) ✓ Sit for your first official SAT or ACT ✓ Review results and adjust your prep plan accordingly ✓ Register for spring test dates early; in some areas, spots fill fast	✓ Retake SAT or ACT if your score has room to improve ✓ Aim to have a strong, near-final score before summer ✓ Confirm testing policies at target schools	✓ Finalize your test strategy well before EA/ED deadlines ✓ Final SAT or ACT retake if needed – complete before November ✓ Send official scores to all schools as required ✓ Confirm score submission requirements for every application

✦ **FORTUNA TIP** Test-optional policies vary widely. Research each school's current stance and factor it into your strategy – some programs and scholarships still require scores even when the college itself is test-optional.

About Fortuna

Using a team-based, high-touch approach, we offer personalized, strategic admissions guidance to help students find the best-fit college where they can flourish and gain entrance to their dream schools. Whether your student is in 9th grade, building their foundation or in 12th grade on the final stretch, Fortuna meets you exactly where you are.

★ Expertise in Our DNA

Our team has evaluated thousands of applications and sat on admissions committees. We don't guess what top colleges look for – we know, because we've been in the room.

◆ Tailored, High-Touch Coaching

No two students are the same. Our approach is fully personalized to your student's strengths, ambitions, and timeline, whether they're just starting out in 9th grade or heading toward deadlines in 12th.

♥ Proven Results

Fortuna students gain admission to top colleges at more than three times average rates. And 40% of our new clients come from word-of-mouth referrals – the greatest testament to our impact.

○ Clarity in a Complex Process

We take the guesswork out of the admissions process, helping you stay organized and focus on what truly matters – so you can apply with confidence.

Real Reviews From Real Clients

Clarity, Confidence, and Dream School Scholarship

My Fortuna coach helped me articulate my story with clarity and confidence. Thanks to her, I'm heading to Yale with a scholarship.

— Eva, Yale Admit



Believed in Me When I Didn't

I can confidently say I couldn't have done it without my coach. Her support and belief in me — even when I doubted myself — helped me get into Harvard.

— George, Harvard Admit



Best Advice. Best Results.

My Fortuna coach always went the extra mile. His advice on Dartmouth and NYU was spot on — and I'm thrilled to be admitted to both!

— Aisha, Dartmouth Admit



About Our Team

Our team consists of former top-tier college admissions officers and seasoned college counselors who bring firsthand expertise in competitive college admissions. Meet a few of our coaches below, and view the full team at fortunaadmissions.com/college/about-us/college-admissions-team/



Judith Silverman Hodara

CO-FOUNDER & DIRECTOR

With nearly three decades at UPenn – reviewing thousands of undergraduate and graduate applications, Judith brings rare insider depth to every engagement. She helps students uncover their unique voice and craft applications that balance authenticity with strategic precision.

Highlights & Achievements

- ▶ Former Associate Director, Domestic & International Admissions, University of Pennsylvania
- ▶ Former Head of Admissions, UPenn Graduate School of Education & Wharton
- ▶ 20,000+ Applications Read and Advised On
- ▶ EdD in Higher Education from UPenn



Lucas Jacob

SENIOR EXPERT COACH & COLLEGE ESSAY SPECIALIST

With over 25 years in education, Luke has guided approximately 1,000 students through applications to top universities, liberal arts colleges, conservatories, and specialized programs worldwide. A National Merit Scholar, Fulbright Teaching Fellow, and published poet whose work has appeared in nearly 100 literary magazines and journals, he brings rare storytelling depth to admissions coaching. Luke helps students craft personal narratives that are both authentic and unforgettable.

Highlights & Achievements

- ▶ Former Director of Writing, Communication, and Media Literacy, La Jolla Country Day School
- ▶ 25+ Years in Education & College Guidance
- ▶ Guided over 1,000 Students Through the College Admissions Process
- ▶ Fulbright Teaching Fellow & Published Author



Maren Savage

SENIOR EXPERT COACH

With admissions experience across Stanford, Berkeley, and Carnegie Mellon, Maren has an unusually rich sense of what top committees respond to. A certified counselor and former finance executive, she combines analytical rigor with genuine warmth to help students present their best selves.

Highlights & Achievements

- ▶ Former Admissions Reader, Stanford University
- ▶ Former Admissions Reader, UC Berkeley & Carnegie Mellon University
- ▶ Certified College Counselor, Member of NACAC
- ▶ MBA, Stanford Graduate School of Business
- ▶ BS in Human Development & Psychology, UC Davis

Your Most Valuable 30 Minutes This Week

Book a free 30-minute consultation with a Fortuna college coach. You'll speak with a former admissions officer who will give you an honest, expert read on your student's profile, and you'll walk away with a clearer picture of the road ahead.

fortunaadmissions.com/college/free-consultation/

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